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California - Gov. Newsom signs 1,040 bills and vetoes 10% sent to him

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Page: 1
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Gov. Gavin Newsom had a lot of decisions to make in 2026.

No, we're not talking about what's next for the termed-out governor who is largely considered to be a possible presidential contender in 2028. But, rather, whether to approve the 1,160 bills the California Legislature sent him this year.

Those bills ranged from providing more training opportunities for people to recognize opioid overdoses and administer naloxone to considering forced marriage as grounds for seeking a domestic violence restraining order. There's legislation requiring high school coaches to complete mental health training to better help their players, and another creating a first-in-the-nation state seal to identify non-ultraprocessed foods.

Of the bills sent to Newsom in 2026, he signed 1,040, meaning he vetoed just 10.3% of them, according to veteran Sacramento lobbyist Chris Micheli's tally.

During his eight years in office, Newsom vetoed 13.5% of the bills that landed on his desk, according to Micheli. That's fairly on par with former Gov. Jerry Brown, also a Democrat, Micheli's research found, but a bit less than Republican Gov. Arnold Schwarzenegger, who clocked in with a 26.5% veto rate.

But back to Newsom, and the final slate of bills before him in his last year as California's governor. .

math in education

Younger students struggling with math will be identified earlier and connected to support faster because of a new law that requires annual math tests to help educators identify these students before academic gaps among classmates grow further.

SB 1067 requires that schools begin testing their kindergartners', first graders' and second graders' math skills annually, starting with the 2028-29 school year. Students identified as needing extra math help through these tests will receive "evidence-based interventions" to help them get back on track, according to bill author Sen. Akilah Weber Pierson, D-San Diego.

The California Department of Education must post online by July 31 the criteria and guidance for selecting appropriate math tests for students, and by the end of January 2028, it will publish a list of approved tests for local education agencies to select from.

Labeling healthy food

California is the first state to pass a law creating an official state seal to identify non-ultraprocessed foods.

AB 2244, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, paves the way for manufacturers to voluntarily undergo evaluation that their products meet the state's definition for non-ultraprocessed foods. Those who meet the standards may affix a "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" state seal on the front of their food packaging to help shoppers easily identify which food products are healthier.

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